

thus saving electricity. It also improves the compressor's longevity. Inverter ACs may cost up to 20 per cent more than conventional models, but provide guaranteed return on your investment.

Go for higher star ratings. Star-rating on electronic and electrical equipment indicates their energy-efficiency level. Higher star-rating implies more savings on your electricity bill.

The Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) provides this score based on certain parameters. Earlier, conventional ACs were scored on the basis of the ratio of their cooling capacity to electricity consumption. The introduction of inverter ACs changed the rating to a different calculation, which takes into account the compressor speed along with cooling capacity and electricity consumption.

Most inverter ACs with the highest energy efficiency are marked as 3-stars. Note that a three-star inverter AC is much more energy-efficient than a five-star non-inverter AC.

Recently, an additional rating method called the Indian Seasonal Energy Efficiency Ratio (ISEER) was introduced. Mentioning the ISEER is not yet mandatory but many vendors choose to display it on their products.

Therefore to pick the most energy-efficient model, first ensure you are comparing ACs from the same category—an inverter AC with another inverter AC, not with a non-inverter AC. Then, among all ratings, go for the highest score.

Choose the capacity according to your room. An AC with a bigger capacity will require a bigger space. ACs come in different capacity levels (measured in tonnes): one tonne, 1.2 tonnes, 1.5 tonnes, 2 tonnes and so on. A 9-13sq.m (100-140sq.ft) area requires one-tonne AC. A 14-16sq.m (150-175sq.ft) room will need 1.5-tonne AC. A larger room with area between 17 and 22sq.m (180 and 240 sq.ft) calls for 2-tonne AC.

AC types. Most inverter ACs come in split models—these have two separate units, interconnected via copper

tubings. While these models require more installation space and effort, they cool a wider area. The cooling is also faster.

Window ACs, on the other hand, are single units fitted usually on the windows of rooms. These are easy to install, space-effective and cost

The best ACs out there

AC manufacturers work on their toes to dole out the most desirable models. We round up a few of the best models available. For easy comparison, we are considering only 1.5-tonne models. You may choose AC capacity as per your requirement.

LG JS-Q18CPXD2.

1.5-tonne inverter AC is a split model with 3-star BEE rating. Energy-efficient copper wiring improves the longevity of the circuit and also the cooling capacity. Moreover, it comes with a dual inverter compressor, which greatly enhances the cooling speed and coverage. The proprietary Gold Fin condenser remains corrosion-free and extends the durability of heat exchange. The AC operates with minimal noise. A two-step filtration system removes dust and bacteria efficiently.

The AC is priced at about ₹ 40,399.

Voltas 183V MY.

Voltas' inverter AC has built-in intelligence to detect the weather. Its Insta-Cool capability quickly brings down the temperature in summer. On the other hand, it keeps the overall temperature comfortably warm during winters. It also checks humidity levels with its Active Dehumidifier. To cut down excessive power usage, the AC can go into sleep mode. The filtration system uses three filters—one for eliminating dust, bacteria, pollen and particulate matters, one for filtering silver ions and the third being an Acaro Bacterium Red filter. The AC can self-diagnose in case of any unprecedented change. It is priced at ₹ 38,000.

Carrier 18K Ester Inverter 3i.

Carrier's 3-star split AC packs a copper condenser that provides quick and efficient cooling. The Esko inverter saves substantial electricity with a turbo mode that can quickly bring down the room's temperature. The louvers reposition themselves automatically to their previous position when the AC is switched on. Auto-restart mode resumes the AC with last active settings automatically if it



LG JS-Q18CPXD2



Voltas 183V MY inverter AC

comparatively less. However, they cool smaller areas, are louder and take slightly more cooling time.

Maintenance is important. Good after-sales service is essential for ACs. Ideally, you should get your AC serviced twice a year. Therefore ensure customer support by the vendor is easily accessible and provides prompt response to service requests. Also evaluate the warranty and the number of free services offered. Vendors offer separate warranties on the complete product, the compressor and the condenser. Usually, the product warranty period is one year. On the other hand, compressors and condensers come with 5-year warranty. Some vendors cover these parts even up to 10 years.

Filters and other features.

Ensure the AC has a strong filtration system. Two or more filters provide extra protection from dust, bacteria, particulate matters and even certain chemicals. Additionally, it increases the filter life, reducing the frequency of servicing required. Apart from filtration, features like smart temperature control, auto-recovery and Wi-Fi connectivity are also advantageous.